

PROMPT: REAL CASES OF DOMESTIC TAMPERING, AND WHAT THEY TEACH

VIOLET'S STORY • v2

2026-09-05. For ChatGPT (Stephen runs it; use a model with web search on) and for a fresh Fable agent (Claude runs it; Fable works from training knowledge and must mark anything unverified). Both receive exactly the text below the line. Results are saved verbatim beside this file; nothing counts as considered until it is in a disposition table.

Record note: v1 of this prompt (the same morning) was run on Fable only, before Stephen's rulings on the spare key and on "workshop". v2 carries those rulings, a do-not-return list from round one, the habit inventory, and a discovery-without-luck requirement. GPT runs v2; Fable's v1 result is dispositioned on arrival and re-run on v2 if it falls short.

Operator context, not for the model: round one (2026-09-03, twenty invented scenarios) produced nothing that stood out. Stephen's diagnosis: the yard and the workshop are reachable by strangers or point at one key-holder, so the threat must be inside her house; and invented scenarios lack the texture of the real. This round grounds the search in documented cases first, then derives candidates from them.

You are researching for a true-crime mystery. Do this in two parts. Read everything before starting. Use web search for part one and give a source for every case.

Part one: the real world

Find and summarise **eight to ten documented real cases**, from any country and any decade, in which someone tampered with a victim's own home, or with an object the victim used in a fixed domestic routine, intending death or serious harm, where the tampering was designed to look like an accident, a fault, or ordinary wear. Include cases where it worked and cases where it failed or was discovered before harm. Prefer tamperers who were intimates: a spouse, partner, relative, lodger, carer, close friend, anyone with a key or the run of the house. Prefer mechanical, electrical, gas, structural or chemical methods over poisoning of food or drink (one or two domestic-routine poisonings are acceptable if the routine is the point). Prefer older terraced or semi-detached housing with gas, solid-fuel or older electrics, since that is the world of the story.

For each case give, in plain prose:

- Where and roughly when, and the relationship between tamperer and victim.
- What was done, physically, in enough detail that a reader could picture it.
- What routine or habit of the victim's it relied on, and how the tamperer knew it.
- How it was discovered, or how it succeeded, and what first made anyone suspicious.
- What the physical evidence was, and whether an ordinary observer, or the first police officer, read it as deliberate or as a fault, wear or coincidence. Say whether police acted on the first report, and if not, why not.
- One sentence on why it is instructive for fiction.

Cite each case with a searchable name and a source. If a detail is not confirmed by a source, mark it UNVERIFIED rather than smoothing it over. No cases with children as victims. No gore.

Part two: what the real world teaches, applied

Design **eight candidate scenarios** for the story below, each descended from a pattern in part one (name the case). Real patterns adapted to this house and this woman, not invented mechanisms.

The woman. Violet Moore, forty-four, a signwriter in a small coastal city. Fit, sharp, physically confident, observant to a fault: she ranks people's handwriting out loud and cannot leave a crooked line alone. She lives alone in a terraced house on Mariner's Row and works from a rented workshop behind the fish market. She is the last person in the city who would believe a friend meant her harm.

Her habits inside the house, all known to the four and to nobody else. She is up before five and out to swim off the harbour slip most mornings from April to November; she comes home cold and wet and warms up fast, and sleeps hard after cold water. She eats standing up at the kitchen counter, fried egg on white, most days. She keeps her cash in a large cookie tin in a kitchen cupboard because she distrusts banks. She reads the last page of a book first, in bed. She smokes two cigarettes a day and lies about it. She works late some evenings at the kitchen table on layouts under a lamp. Her house is old, with the older kind of gas, electrics and plumbing. You may add one small habit of your own if a scenario needs it, but say that you added it.

The four. Her closest friends. Nobody but Violet holds a cut key to her house; the spare lives in a hiding place all four know and have each used at some point. Ruby, a nurse, is her Tuesday-morning friend and sits in the car with her afterwards with the heater on. Liam has known her since they were eleven. Margo does her books. Brad, a younger signwriter she taught for seven years, has a key to her workshop, not her house. All four have been inside the house; nobody else in the city has, socially, in years.

Hard constraints on every candidate. Show how each is met.

1. The tampering is **inside her house**. Not the yard, not the street, not the workshop, not the slip, not the car. Nothing a stranger could reach by climbing a fence or walking past. The whole evidence of intimacy is that someone was inside her home.
2. Access needed the spare key from its hiding place and knowledge of a habit only the four have watched. It points at all four equally.
3. It was aimed at her specifically, at something she does every day or every week, not at the house in general.
4. She survives it unhurt or barely hurt: a near miss, or a preparation she discovers before it is used. **She discovers it through her own attention, not through luck:** say what she noticed and why she, of all people, would notice it. No falls, no stairs, no ladders. She keeps working and swimming afterwards.
5. When she inspects it she finds a physical detail that says deliberate rather than accident or wear: unscrewed not sheared, placed not fallen, cut not frayed, present that should be absent or absent that should be present. She can keep it or photograph it.
6. To a competent police officer, and to any tradesman she might call, the same detail reads as nothing: old wiring, wear, a slipped memory. No lab could settle it in a day. There is no offence to record and no suspect to name. She knows how it would sound.
7. Had it worked, she dies, and a reader believes that without a paragraph of explanation. Not intimidation, not a prank, not a slow bet.

8. One tampering, not two coordinated ones.

9. It leaves her frightened enough to arrange for her own death without telling any of the four, and to write to them together rather than confront one.

Do not return these; they were considered and set aside. Anything with a ladder, stairs or a fall. Anything in the car, the yard, the workshop or on the slip. A closed stove damper or blocked heater vent paired with a disabled carbon monoxide alarm (two tamperings, and the standard television murder). A wedged kettle switch or a plugged pressure-cooker vent (modern cut-outs). A moved clothes peg by a heater. Two clocks set forward. A swapped electric-blanket controller. A window restrictor removed or shortened (access without an attempt). A cut sash cord. Petrol in a paraffin can (a lab settles it). If your best candidate is a single-tampering cousin of one of these, say so and argue why it clears the objection.

For each candidate, in this order, plain prose, no headings inside it:

- The real pattern it descends from (which case in part one).
- The event, in two or three sentences, as it happens to her.
- The habit it exploited and why only the four know it.
- How she comes to look, and what she finds: the detail, and why it says deliberate to her.
- Why it says nothing to an officer or a tradesman.
- What she keeps or photographs.
- The one thing that would make it fail as story, named honestly.

Then a forced ranking of the eight, best first, one sentence per rank on why it beat the one below. No ties, no scores. Finish with your sources for part one, listed.

Write plainly. No em dashes.